

With the promise of getting a solution in three months, Nir-malamatha Central School handed over one lakh rupees to the TutAR trio – Shyam, Suvith and Thomson – and the work began. In the meantime, almost five more schools came forward, and the first version of the app was rolled out in the month of August with a modest fund of around rupees five lakh. “We started with zero. Around the time we registered ourselves, we had around ₹5 lakh to ₹6 lakh, and in three months, we had an app and a full-fledged team of about 30 members,” Thomson said.

Currently, the founders say that TutAR is used by around 200+ schools and over 25,000 teachers across India as well as a few dozens of teachers from Russia, Egypt and the Middle East. The schools are mostly situated in South India – Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka – with a few up in the North, including Delhi, Jammu, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. TutAR has curated a library of over 5000 3-D models. The company also recently raised an undisclosed amount in its seed round from April Ventures and SalesboxAI’s founder Roy Ranjan, which the company said in an official statement that it will be



used for bolstering technology and hiring world-class content. Along with it, the company sells a contract to a school for around ₹50,000, in which as many as 25 teachers can use the app.

THE FUTURE OF TUTAR: TUTARVERSE

With the plans of expanding across India underway, the founders are also shifting the goalpost. They want to

create a metaverse, where students and teachers can collaborate virtually, leveraging augmented as well as virtual reality. “Online education is here to stay. We want it to make it more interactive and bring one-on-one interaction between teachers and students in the ring of online education, too”, Thomson said. The founders are expecting to roll out the metaverse, or so to speak, Tutarverse, in a few months. On the sidelines of all-consuming work, Thomson also has an interesting tale to tell. When he was in college, he was the boss; he ran campus startups. His parents were worried. “My parents wanted me to become a banker, which was considered a safe, secure job. Both of Shyam’s parents were also government employees; they wanted him to follow suit,” he said. In the parents-teachers meeting, Thomson’s teachers told his parents that he might be good, but it would not be worth it if the grades fall.

With half-a-chuckle and little gleam in his eyes, Thomson said, “Now my parents advise other youngsters that they should also apply their brains outside classrooms, maybe run a startup or two.” There might not be any need to say it, but anyway here it goes: Thomson never entered the job market, and he’s proud. **[i]**

